While permission from Delhi was awaited, Maj. Gen. Brar made one more attempt to get his men into the Akal Takht with the help of the Skot OT64 armoured personnel carrier. The plan was to drive the APC right up to the Akal Takht so that men from the mechanized infantry could get in under the cover of a wall. But the APC soon came under attack from RPG (rocket propelled grenade) launchers. One of the grenades found its mark and the APC was knocked off.

Final clearance from New Delhi for the use of tanks came at about 7 a.m. on 6 June. Eight Vijayanta tanks from the 16th Cavalry Regiment with their main 105 mm high-explosive squash head shells were deployed. By the time the operation was over the tanks had fired about eighty shells, and the effect of the high-explosive squash-head shells on the building and its inmates was devastating. [20] In the process, much of the Akal Takht, the shrine which according to the original orders was to suffer as little damage as possible, was in a shambles.

There are conflicting views about the burning of the library, which had invaluable manuscripts of historical value, including copies of the Granth Sahib handwritten by some of the gurus. Some Sikhs believe the army deliberately set it on fire to destroy an important part of the Sikh cultural heritage. But, according to the government white paper, the library caught fire accidentally in the exchange of fire. [21]

By late afternoon on 6 June, the army was in control of the situation in both the complexes and curfew was lifted for two hours. During that period, nearly 250 people who were trapped in the main temple complex rooms overlooking the parikrama had surrendered.

After dealing with all the officials of the temple who surrendered that day, the army once again turned its attention to the Akal Takht. The sniping from there had died down, but Maj. Gen. Brar was not willing to risk losing any more lives by sending his men into the Akal Takht by daylight. He waited for dusk to fall before giving orders to his troops to storm the Akal Takht and shoot anyone who came in the way. There was no resistance from inside the building. Brar set a guard on it and decided to wait for daylight before starting a search of the premises. According to the army, it was during that